Hackers Hit Supermarket Fridges Across Europe

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Hackers attacked supermarket fridges across Europe on Monday. Fridges and freezers in stores from Sweden to Belgium got too warm, so stores had to throw away **spoiled** food.

The attack hit dozens of stores. It hit supermarket groups Ahold Delhaize and Colruyt in Belgium and Luxembourg, and Swedish grocers ICA and Coop. At least one Ikea store was also affected.

At an ICA store in Stockholm, sales manager Engla Ingwall said the attack happened at 2 a.m. but was only noticed hours later. "Everything is destroyed," she said. "All our freezers reached 50 degrees [Celsius]."

No one has claimed responsibility for either attack. European **authorities** are worried about threats to important systems. Moscow has denied involvement.

Katrien Eggers, spokesperson for Belgium's Centre for Cybersecurity, said it is not known who is behind the attack, and it may never be determined. She said all computer systems can be **vulnerable**, and **artificial** intelligence can now be used to exploit these weaknesses.

Word Treasure

hackers -- People who break into computer systems to cause damage.
spoiled -- Food that has gone bad and is no longer safe to eat.
vulnerable -- Easy to hurt or attack because of a weakness.
authorities -- People or groups in charge of keeping a place safe and running.
artificial -- Made by people or machines, not natural.

Background you need

A hacker attack happens when someone breaks into a computer system to damage it or take control of it.

Many supermarket fridges are run by computers, so if hackers change their settings, the food inside can warm up and spoil.

That is why attacks on food stores worry people: one attack can spoil food in many shops at once.

Break it down

WHO: Hackers, supermarket groups, Engla Ingwall, and Katrien Eggers.
WHAT: A hacking attack raised fridge and freezer temperatures, spoiling food.
WHERE: Supermarket stores from Sweden to Belgium, including a store in Stockholm.
WHY: No one has claimed responsibility, and authorities worry about threats to important systems.

Why it matters

If fridges in shops stop working properly, the food your family buys could spoil, so keeping shop computers safe matters to everyone.

Test what you remember

1. What did hackers attack in Europe on Monday?

- (A) School computers
- (B) Supermarket fridges
- (C) Phones
- (D) Cars

2. What happened to the food in the fridges?

- (A) It spoiled and had to be thrown away
- (B) It turned into ice
- (C) It got colder
- (D) It was sold faster

3. At what time did the attack happen at the ICA store in Stockholm?

- (A) At 2 a.m.
- (B) At noon
- (C) At bedtime
- (D) At 6 p.m.

4. What did a similar attack in France do last month?

- (A) It closed one shop
- (B) It made food cheaper
- (C) It hit hundreds of supermarkets and caused fires and food losses
- (D) It fixed all fridges

5. Has anyone claimed responsibility for the attacks?

- (A) No one has claimed responsibility
- (B) Yes, a group in Sweden
- (C) Yes, ICA
- (D) Yes, Moscow

6. What did Katrien Eggers say about computer systems?

- (A) They can be vulnerable, and AI can exploit weaknesses
- (B) Only old systems break
- (C) They never break
- (D) They are all perfectly safe

Answer key (try the quiz first!): 1: B 2: A 3: A 4: C 5: A 6: A

Questions to think about

1. European authorities: Worried about threats to important systems.
2. Moscow: Has denied involvement in sabotage.
3. Katrien Eggers: Said it is not known who is behind the attack and that computer systems can be vulnerable.

MY THOUGHTS (at least 20 words):